your CV

good to know

What you need to know about your photo, page 3 and your recommendation and references.

PAGE 3

In exceptional cases, you may find it hard to fit all the important information on just two pages in your CV. “Page 3” is an option for PhD students, for example, as a way of showcasing their research or teaching. You can craft a skills profile complete with your additional competencies here to let readers see all of your assets for this job at a glance. Whether it’s publications or the main areas your work has focused on, you can put specific experiences and qualifications in this section. However, always make sure that you’re just including information relevant to the job. Under no circumstances should you see page 3 as a license to overload your document with even more details.

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PHOTO

As the saying goes: a picture says more than a thousand words. So be careful about what you are messaging with your photo. Whoever takes a look at it will definitely draw conclusions from the picture quality. It shows how much effort you've put into compiling your documents and how professional you want to present yourself. Therefore, note:

1. Go for a professional photographer – you'll even be able to offset the costs against your tax bill. **2.** Think carefully about what to wear, pick high-quality materials, and avoid brash colors and eccentric patterns. Women should wear a blouse and/or blazer and men a shirt and suit jacket – plus a tie too depending on what industry the job is in. You should also have had a recent haircut, while women shouldn't wear too much makeup. **3.** Sit up straight and don't slouch your shoulders. Look into the camera with a friendly, yet determined gaze.

Although a photo is no longer required these days, it's still fairly common in Germany. A 2017 study by the management consultants Kienbaum revealed that 82 per cent of HR managers didn't consider an application complete without a photo.

By the way:
At the TUM Career Days *www.community.tum.de/career-days* and at the IKOM, the Career Forum at TUM *www.ikom.tum.de*, you can have your photo taken by professional photographers for free.

LETTERS OF RECOMMENDATION

In Germany, you are required to provide copies of your written employment references (Arbeitszeugnisse) as part of your application portfolio. (You can learn all about this document on page 222).

If you haven't worked in Germany before, you can substitute these with letters of recommendation. Letters of recommendation – from your doctoral supervisor, seminar lead, or a previous manager – can be a great way to reveal a bit more about yourself, particularly if you're just embarking on your career. They provide evidence of your unique strengths, abilities, achievements, or talents. A letter of recommendation shouldn't be more than one page long and should be written in the first person.

REFERENCES

Occasionally you might be asked to provide references during your application process. Please note that these do not belong on the CV itself, but are submitted separately.

Select people for this who know you through different projects, e.g. one academic and one internship supervisor. Ensure to ask your reference providers whether they are on board before sharing their contact details with any prospective employers.

A complete reference includes the person's full name, job title and their place of work, as well as their relationship with you. Provide one email address as well as one phone number.

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German language skills

Knowledge of the German language is a great advantage when searching for a job in Germany. Taking a German language course at the beginning of your studies and seeking contact with German-speaking students is therefore strongly advised. The TUM Language Center (TUM Sprachenzentrum) offers you different formats of learning German. The program also includes courses for developing intercultural competence for easing the way into the German job market. Even if you are able to have a basic conversation in German, you might still feel uncomfortable submitting your application documents in German. Here are some basic rules that might help you to decide in which language you should apply:

TUM TIP

TUM offers international students a variety of opportunities to learn German or improve their German skills: for example through the language courses offered by the TUM Language Center, the TUMi Language Café, TUMtandem or the German hub. The various TUM Student Clubs also offer the opportunity to improve language skills – as German is best learned by speaking and being with other students.

www.sprachenzentrum.tum.de
www.international.tum.de/campuslife
www.tum.de/en/community/campus-life/student-clubs

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good to know

1

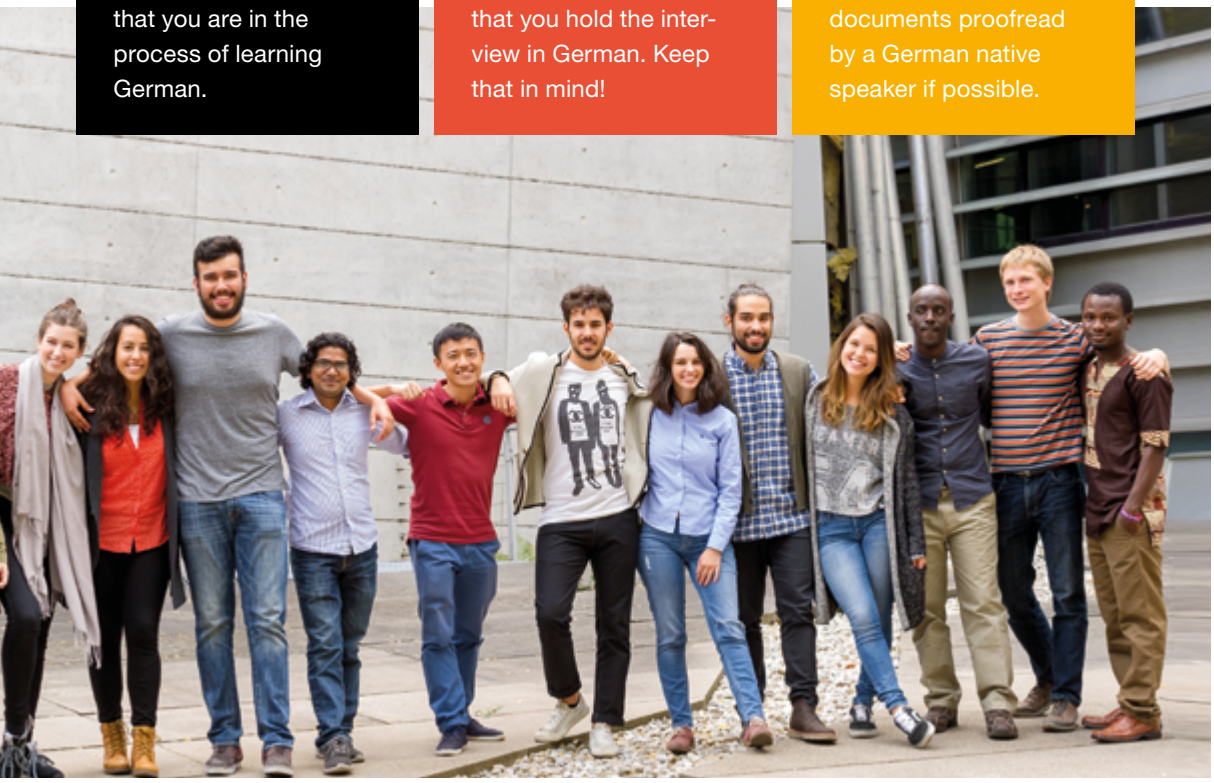
Don't, on any account, send in application documents in English for a job that was advertised in German only. Find out in advance by telephone if knowledge of German is a requirement, or whether it is possible to submit your application in English. Emphasize that you are in the process of learning German.

2

If you submit your application documents in German, it is expected that you hold the interview in German. Keep that in mind!

3

If you decide to write in German, it is not necessary to have a perfect command of German. However, try to avoid making obvious mistakes by having your documents proofread by a German native speaker if possible.



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